

Breeding

Once in Europe, the swallows form breeding pairs. The male courts a female with flying displays, singing, and by showing his tail. If the female is impressed, the pair will mate. Pairs sometimes stay together for life.

Flying north

In spring, barn swallows leave Africa and travel thousands of miles to their breeding sites in Europe. They feed while flying and drink by scooping up water as they fly low over lakes and rivers.

Nesting

In the roof of a building, the pair make a cup-shaped nest out of mud. The female lays three to seven eggs. Sometimes, the male helps the female incubate the eggs.

See also

Read about the big brown bat (128–129), who also uses buildings to breed.

The parents catch insects for the chicks and keep the nest clean.

Feeding chicks

The eggs hatch after about two weeks. The helpless chicks need constant feeding. By the time they are around three weeks old, they have grown feathers and are ready to fly.

Bar-tailed godwit This bird holds the record for the longest nonstop bird flight. One godwit traveled more than 6,800 miles (11,000 km) on a continuous journey as it migrated from New Zealand to the Yellow Sea in China.



Bar-headed goose This Asian goose has been tracked flying at nearly 24,000 ft (7,300 m) over the Himalayan Mountains—higher than any other migrating bird.

